Grade 9: Level 6 = 30 marks

Both Percy Shelley and Robert Browning explore ideas about arrogance and control, and about tyrants who value their power over human life. Shelley, writing near the time of the French Revolution, in which people rose up against a tyrannical monarchy, writes about someone whose power has faded away, and, as a Romantic poet, points out how man is humbled in the face of nature. Robert Browning, on the other hand is writing in response to a story about the Duke of Ferrara, a cruel duke who clung onto control and whose wife died in mysterious circumstances.

Shelley describes a statue in a distant land, whose "shatter'd visage" is "half-sunk". The "visage" is perhaps a metaphor for the king's identity, his ideals, his power and Shelley makes a point of highlighting that it is "shatter'd" and "sunk", that is, his power is broken, taken away, sinking in the "lone level sands", which are symbolic of time, to represent how his tyranny and authority have been washed away, destroyed by time, faded into history. The speaker himself is separate from the statue, having heard of it from a "traveller", and this distance adds to the sense that Ozymandias' power has disappeared. However Browning presents ideas about a tyrant who still exerts power and control. The first line in the poem is "that's my last Duchess painted on the wall", and the possessive pronoun "my" gives it a sinister tone, implying ownership over the duchess, who is only ever defined by her status as his wife, as, in the duke's eyes, she only exists to worship him. This sense of possession is emphasised in a later line, in which the duke mentions he's the only one with the power to "draw" the "curtain" to the painting, and Browning gives perhaps even a sense of morbid pleasure as the duke says this, as he couldn't control who looked at the duchess in life, he can now that she's dead, being able to hide or expose her as he pleases.

Both poets express the tyrant's boasting, highlighting their annoyance and pride. Shelley describes the inscription in which Ozymandias describes himself as "King of Kings", perhaps alluding to himself as being a God, ruler of all, maybe even immortal, as he believed his power would last forever. There's a sense of irony here as Shelley describes that a "colossal wreck" is all there's left of his power. The oxymoron in "colossal wreck" maybe even mocks Ozymandias as it points out how his arrogant boast about his authority is in the middle of the ruins of his broken statue. Browning also expresses the duke's arrogance through boasting, as he mentions the "gift of a nine hundred years name". The word "gift" has connotations of charity, and implies the duchess should be thankful of everything the duke gives her, should worship him like a God as she's beneath him and should be glad he even gives her his time.

Both poets use very strict structures to emphasise the need for control that that characters have. Shelley uses a sonnet, a very controlled form, ironically as Ozymandias' power has faded. Sonnets are also typically about love, and there's a sense of mockery as Ozymandias is in love with himself and his power, but everyone else has forgotten about him and his arrogance. Browning uses rhyming couplets throughout My Last Duchess, to symbolise the duke's control and authority. There's perhaps something sinister there as it is suggested his wife didn't even want to be with him in life, the couplets might imply she now doesn't have a choice or even that his next wife won't, having even less liberty than the Duchess. Although the couplets show his control, Browning uses more and more enjambment in the duke's dramatic monologue, to show he's being carried away by his anger, but maybe as well to imply he is also losing his power, and desperately holding onto it. It may be that the message of both poets was that control and tyranny are unsustainable and are eventually lost.

Response to text / task

Textual references

Writer's methods

Context

This is a conceptualised response in terms of the way that the candidate has a central thesis about power and uses both poems to illustrate and exemplify their ideas. The use of specific references is continually skilful and extremely judicious in selection, and the analysis of methods is blended seamlessly into an exploration of the ideas presented in both poems.